

Research Paper:
Romans 8 - What is the New Life in the Spirit?

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“The Law of the Spirit of Life has set you free from the the law of sin and death.”

This verse in the beginning of Romans 8 sets the tone for the entire chapter of Romans 8. This verse is saying that the Holy Spirit allows us to have freedom from the chains and bondage of sin. The New Life in the Holy Spirit and as a Christian is the theme of Romans 8. Isn't this great news that we can have a new life? This new life is not just here and now, and is not just our individual life, but is all of creation. All creation, heavens and earth will be renewed. We will live in a perfect environment and have a perfect mind, body, and spirit. This salvation that we have is perfect and imperishable as Paul says elsewhere in the New Testament, and is more than we can ask or imagine (Ephesians). There are several questions, however. My thesis is: Romans 8 explains how we have the new life in relation to our sinful nature, that this new life is available to all people, this resurrection and new life is from Ezekiel and is a fairly new concept to the Jews, we are forensically justified in the new life, and all creation will be renewed along with us.

Dr. Kim wrote a good paper on “The Holy Spirit in Romans 8 and the ‘I’ in 7:14-25.”¹ And the reason why I say this is because this topic of how Romans 7 relates to the Romans 8 is one of the most important parts of understanding the significance of Romans 8. Romans 7 talks about how we are bound to sin and are unable to do what is right even when we try. Kim points out the main question that theologians have is: “Is Romans 7 talking of a Christian or a non-Christian?” Douglas Moo points out “the lack of mention of the Spirit” in Romans 7, which means that Moo thinks it's a non-Christian. But Kim is adamant that the fact that he is struggling with sin and knows it, and declares

¹ Kim, Hyun-Gwang. “The Holy Spirit in Romans 8 and the ‘I’ in 7:14-25.” 신약연구 23, no. 1 (December 31, 2024): 44–78.

at the end of the chapter that Jesus is able to save, is an indication that the Holy Spirit is alive in the person of Romans 7. My personal opinion to answer this question is for us to look at ourselves - do we struggle with sin? The answer is yes. Therefore, Romans 7 could easily and feasibly talk of a Christian.

But what is the significance of this, you may ask. And the significance is: although we struggle with sin (Romans 7), the new life in the spirit (Romans 8) shows us that we have the overwhelming victory over sin. Once again, I will repeat the beginning verse of Romans 8: "For the law of the Spirit of Life has set you free from the Law of Sin and Death." As you can see, the Holy Spirit frees us from the bondage of Romans 7. In Romans 7, we see a man who is struggling with sin and cannot do the right thing. He wants to do what is right, but cannot. But the Holy Spirit frees us from this law that traps us, and sets us free by allowing us to have freedom to do what we truly want to do in the Lord. We are able to actually do what is right, and to not do what is wrong. As we see later in Romans 8, Paul says to put to death the sin in our flesh and to do the righteous things in the spirit. Romans 8 has a constant contrast between the Spirit and the mind set on the spirit and the flesh and the mind set on the flesh. "We have an obligation not to indulge in the flesh," but to live in the Spirit, Paul says. Therefore, the application point is this: as a Christian, we are able to truly live a good life and do what is right. We are victors. As Romans 8 says, we are more than conquerors. The overwhelming victory is ours even though we may struggle with sin because the Holy Spirit is working in us. Even though we don't know what to do at times, or how to pray, the Holy Spirit is praying for us and working in us in a way that we cannot dictate.

Oh, what great news this is! That I cannot destroy myself and that I have no fear of destruction or sin!

The next question we can ask is, “Can I get this new life? Is it only for the Jews?” And as we learned in class, Romans is addressed primarily for the Jewish Christians, but also is addressed to the Gentile Christians. We see this because in Romans 1, the sins of idolatry are the sins that Gentile Christians would do. Also, Romans 3 speaks of Gentiles and Jews being under sin - both alike. And so, we see Paul saying that both Gentile and Jews are bound under sin before salvation, and that salvation for both of them come through Jesus Christ. And thus, Paul says, salvation is for the Jew first, then the Gentile. Although the Bible is very Jew-centric, we see that the Gentiles have been grafted into the olive tree in order for the Gentiles to part-take in the new life of Romans 8. Romans 7 is slightly different from the Gentile because the Gentile does not have the law. But I assure you, that as people who have original sin (Gentile and Jew), everyone struggles with sin and cannot do what they truly want to do - even now. Thus, salvation comes to the Jew first, then the Gentile. And we see that Romans 8 speaks life to the Gentile as well as the Jew. Thus, the application is this: you too can have this new life in Christ. It is available to everyone who believes.

According to Kowalski², we see that Christianity is “nonethnic” even though Judaism is “an ethnic, particularistic Judaism.” “Adoption is a way to describe the change that occurs when gentiles are baptized into Christ” (Kowalski). As we see in Romans 8, adoption is a big concept. Adoption causes us to be sons and daughters of God and allows us to call God as Father in an intimate, familiar way. We can call God,

² Kowalski, Marcin. “The Brokerage of the Spirit in Romans 8.” The Catholic Biblical Quarterly 80, no. 4 (December 31, 2018): 636–54.
<https://research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=4aac9720-a94e-3654-be50-976613ae30f5>.

“Abba, father.” This is unheard of in the Old Testament. And this adoption is available to Gentiles as well as the Jews. “All who are baptized into Christ share with him the Spirit and the image of the Father, becoming thus the ‘seed of Abraham.’” This shows that as a Christian, we become seeds of Abraham and are children of the promise - the promise that was made to Abraham that God would bless all the nations through him. And so the application is: yes, you too are a child of Abraham and a Christian who can live the new life in the Spirit and share in the blessings of the Jews and God.

According to Sparkman³, we see that Isaiah 50:8-9 is very similar to Romans 8:31-34. This correlation between the Old Testament and New Testament should not be surprising because Paul used the Old Testament as the basis for all his arguments. The similarities between these two passages are not insignificant. They both start off with “who will bring any charge against us?” (Romans). Then they both say that “it is God who justifies.” (Romans). Isaiah says, “He who vindicates me is near.” And then, “Who is my accuser?” Finally, they both say, “Who will condemn us?” (Romans and Isaiah). As you can see, they are almost exactly the same in meaning. According to Thielman, “The echo of Isaiah 50:8-9 is too close to be accidental.” Thus, the scholars agree that this passage of Romans is directly quoting from Isaiah. But the question we can ask is, how does this relate to our actual lives and our spiritual lives when we are thinking about the life in the Spirit? What we see is that our life in the Spirit is not just something that happens in the New Testament, but happened in the Old Testament as well. Isaiah was foreshadowing and prophesying of a time when the Holy Spirit would fill each true Israelite and that the real justification of a person is not based on their works, but on

³ Sparkman, Zach. “If God Is for Us: Paul’s Use of Isaiah in Romans 8.” *Criswell Theological Review* 21, no. 2 (December 31, 2024): 81–97.

their faith and election by God. I think this is the most important concept - that our justification is based on our election by God. When God chooses someone, there is no doubt or escaping of the favor of Goodness upon that person. That person receives grace and mercy and all sorts of benefits. In some sense, according to my professor Stephen Whatley of Faith International University, God is “very, very partial toward his children.” What we can feel, is that God has a fatherly affection and dedication toward us, in that he will go out of his way to say anything possible in order to make us justified and in the right. This is the image of the father in the story of the Prodigal Son. The Father puts a ring on the adulterous son, and creates a huge feast for the son even after he did a terrible deed. This partiality should comfort us in that we can feel safe that no matter what we do, “who can condemn us?” (Romans).

As you can see, this partiality keeps us safe and allows us to be free. One of the big themes of Life in the Spirit is that of freedom. As you can see in the beginning of Romans 8, it says, “the Law of the Spirit of life has set you free from the law of sin and death.” From this, we see that we have been “set free.” This means that we do not have to watch ourselves and be so wise - we can be like simple children! We can just do what we feel and make mistakes. I think this idea of freedom is incredibly controversial because most Christians would say, “We need to follow the Law,” which goes against Galatians.

The Law and the Spirit of Life are two concepts that are incredibly difficult concepts to reconcile. As we see in the middle of Romans 8, Paul says that through the Spirit, we must put to death the deeds of the flesh. This shows that we are not to just do anything we want, and be totally “free.” But, what I think the resolution to this

problem is, is that freedom in the Spirit is freedom when we are doing the right things and under the watch of God. When the Spirit is directing our actions, we are free, and we will do what is right. We will put to death the deeds of the flesh.

According to Warnez⁴, the phrase “subjected to futility” is a phrase that appears in Romans 8 and Genesis. It appears in Romans 8 because it says that all creation groans for redemption and is subjected to futility. It appears in Genesis 3:17-18 when Adam and Eve sin and the creation is “subjected to futility.” What the main point of all these passages is is that the natural world has fallen. We see this in everyday media - why are the porn stars and celebrities and the drunkards and the terrible people the famous people on television and in society? Why are there earthquakes and natural disasters? Why do we Christians sin everyday and all people hurt each other every minute? The answer to all these questions is that “creation has been subjected to futility.”

Now, this leads to a very important philosophical and theological issue. It says that there is something wrong and that there used to be something perfect about the world. This is an incredibly controversial statement because many atheists will say that the world was never perfect and has always been this way - it has never been subjected to futility, everything has always been this way, and is futile. But the Bible and God say that this world used to be perfect and sin came into the world and caused all the problems of the universe. It's an incredible statement because sin on this earth is the cause of all the problems of the entire universe! Also, it says that there is something called perfect. We humans are always yearning for the eternal and imperishable thing

⁴ “On Romans 8 and the Integrity of Creation.” The Catholic Biblical Quarterly 86, no. 2 (December 31, 2024): 326–47.

and eternal life. As you can see, almost every culture has a religion, in order to seek a higher power and a higher meaning, and something greater than ourselves. From this, we can see that the Bible is confirmed and that our greatest hopes have a chance of being fulfilled, because if it was subjected to futility, creation has a chance of returning back to perfection if the Bible is true.

In conclusion, we see that the Spirit of Life has a law - it is the Law of the Spirit of Life. And this Law goes against the Law of Sin and Death. This is easy to understand - God and the Holy Spirit are going against the bad things in this universe. An easy way to understand all this Spirit language is to say that the Holy Spirit is in the business of making things better and making us good. We are justified in Christ and in the Spirit because "who can condemn us?" as Isaiah and Romans 8 says? And also, we have freedom in the Holy Spirit because we have been set free from the law of sin and death. As we can see, we have freedom and life and we have so many good things for us in the Spirit. We even have election and the hope that all creation will return to its perfect state. The idea of the Spirit should fill us with hope and joy and cause us to understand that "all things work together for our good" (Romans 8).

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